

And Good Night

For years, America sat rapt in front of their TV sets understanding their world as explained by Walter Cronkite. At the end of each news broadcast, Cronkite would hold a glass up to the camera and say, “I toast you America,” and continue in a low hoarse voice “...and that’s the way it is.” There was a time, however, when CBS faced a problem. Cronkite, in the midst of a mid-life crisis, had jetted off to Nassau with a young hottie, leaving the network with a void in its nightly news show. But they had prepared for this eventuality and had in reserve Cronkite’s identical twin brother, also named Walter.

The news show itself was covered by other reporters, but they needed Cronkite for the signoff. Walter-two was shoved in front of a camera and given a glass to raise. He dutifully read his line, ending “...and that’s the way it is.” But it came out in Walter-two’s nasal falsetto. The network’s ratings tanked, and they learned the sad lesson that you can take a drink to Walter, but you can’t make him hoarse.

